

Session 25: Introduction to Ezekiel's Temple Vision

Key Takeaways

- In the design of the Ezekiel scroll, Ezekiel's temple vision in chapters 40-48 links back to Ezekiel's visions and the corrupted temple of chapters 1-8.
- Passages describing the dimensions of the tabernacle or temple provide readers with the opportunity to meditate on the space where Heaven and Earth are one.
- God gives Moses and David a "pattern" of what the people will build, but God shows Ezekiel a completed temple.

Meditating on the Shape of God's Holy Space

Two analogies to help us understand Ezekiel's temple vision.

First, picture a current map of the United States. All the lines that make up the current state borders are the result of a long process of land acquisition and represent centuries of political, economic, and social interests. Imagine a modern-day Ezekiel, convinced that from its origins this arrangement of space is founded on greed and corruption. His equivalent "American vision" would result in a map of perfect symmetrical and proportionate design, so that each state received the same amount of space, and all past wrongs have been made right in this new arrangement. And, just as importantly, the centers of power would all be rearranged, so that the national cathedral would be placed at the exact center of the continent, while the U.S. Capitol and the White House would be de-centered and placed in subordination to the central cathedral. The vision would be a form not just of future hope, but it would constitute a powerful critique of America's past and present. This is precisely the purpose of Ezekiel's vision as stated in [43:1-11](#).

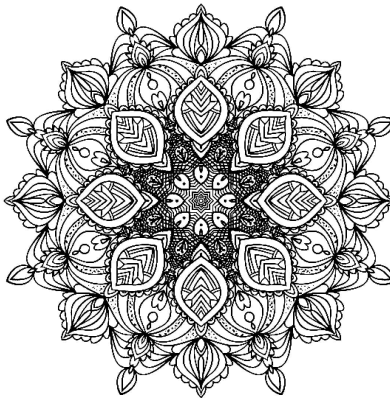
Second, consider meditative labyrinths in the Christian and Buddhist traditions.

There is an ancient tradition in Christian mysticism and spiritual formation of physically walking through a symmetrically designed labyrinth as one meditates and prays. The physical experience of walking in symmetries corresponds to a series of prayer and meditation practices that aid one in turning the prayer over and over again, seeing it from different angles so that one can ponder and raise these musings up to the presence of God.



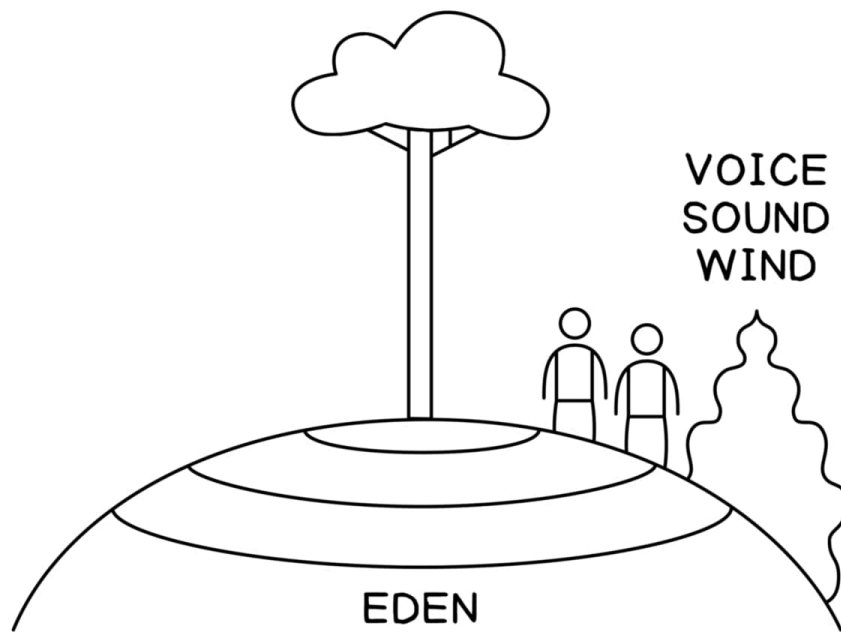
Prayer Labyrinth. awfumc.org

Similarly, Susan Niditch (in “Ezekiel 40-48 in Visionary Context,” p. 213), compares Ezekiel’s vision to the mandalas of Buddhist visionaries. A mandala was a symmetrical drawing that represented the cosmic order, and meditation and concentration on the mandala led one to imagine traveling about the universe pondering its order, beauty, and divine nature.



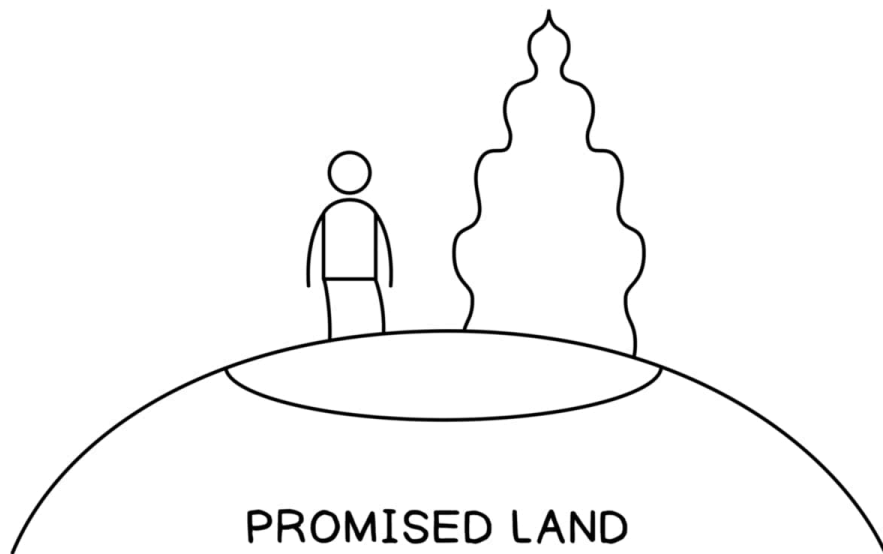
Dummies.com (2023). “What Are Mandalas?”

A Tale of Many Cosmic Mountains



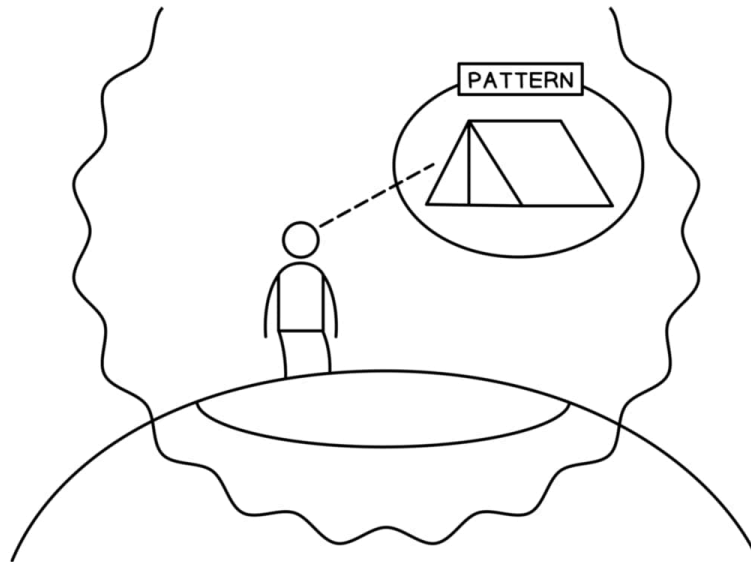
GEN 2-3

A Tale of Many Cosmic Mountains 1. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



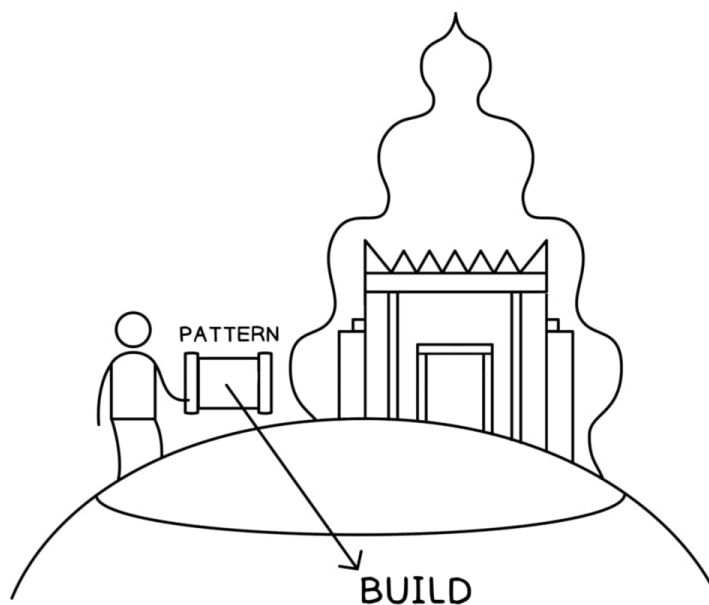
GEN 13:14-18

A Tale of Many Cosmic Mountains 2. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



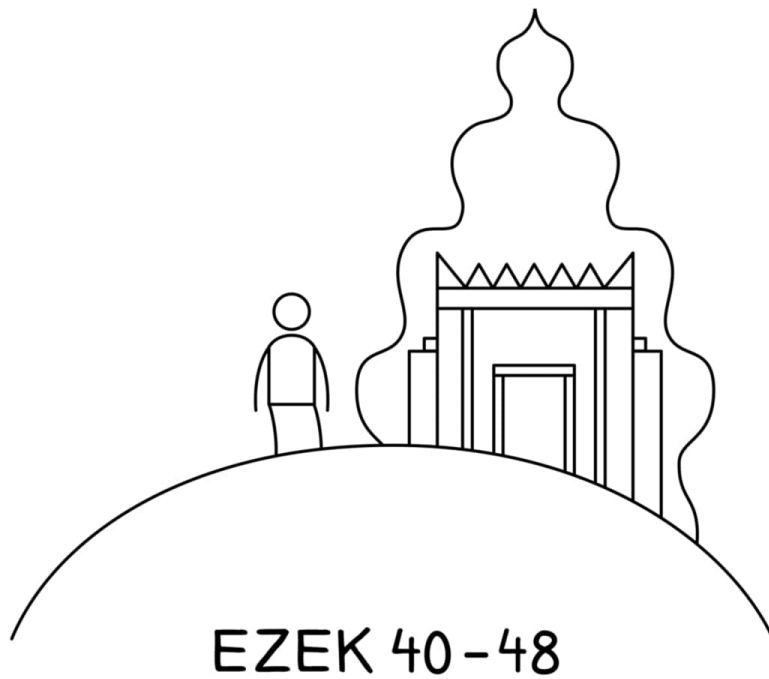
EXOD 24-31

A Tale of Many Cosmic Mountains 3. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



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A Tale of Many Cosmic Mountains 4. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).



A Tale of Many Cosmic Mountains 5. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

What meaning or benefit can modern readers derive from lengthy descriptions of temple dimensions?